



Marg Sep 2020 - Raghava KK

The most critical issue I face in the wake of this pandemic and my future vision

On March 6th, I got a frantic call from a gallerist telling me that all my commissioned works (half a million dollar worth) have been cancelled. It felt to me, then, like a total overreaction. A few weeks later, forced lockdown and self quarantine ensued. With utter confusion about the state of the world, I began calling up artist friends and galleries to gauge the situation across the board. The story was the same - confusion and disruption.

Refusing to go on the defensive, I began rethinking my relationship with art. These crazy times complicated this process further by showing me that the private and the public have changed overnight so suddenly that any understanding of the landscape I once had to create my artworld constructions, may no longer exist.

My biggest aha-moment occurred when I realised that art and life, once almost melded into each other for me, were actually not only in need of separation but almost required opposite mindsets. My private identity, the objective of which for me is spiritual (deconstructing any notions of self) was diametrically in opposition to my public identity (one that involved me creating the most glorious and sacred construction of a persona) whose objective was survival. Survival of an idea, an experience, a persona etc.

Having discovered that there were values I lived by, values I believed in, it was now my duty to embark on a new art journey to embody those ideas and ideals in the objects I made. I started on a journey to radically change my practice. I wanted my art to integrate— in process, in artwork, in medium and object—my whole self, my aesthetics, my ideas, my essential being.

In the world of identity performance and social media influencer circles which I have moved around in, 'brand' meant promise. Borrowing from this idea, I started to treat every artwork or body of artworks as a brand promise. The promise of an experiential encounter with a concept (most artists in the art world try to create brands too but with less nakedly capitalistic language, and a lot more hypocrisy). This again failed me miserably as no single concept or a collection of concepts represented my persona.

Having established that the meaning of life is an existential wasteland for me, a big epiphany for me happened when I realised that, **within the confines of an art series or artwork, integrity could have very specific goals.** I could both live life with specific role-goals and also create art with a sense of staying true to a persona. I'd like to call this moral nihilism (yes! I am giving it a very different meaning than what that phrase usually means)

The meaning of life for the moral-nihilist comes from the performance of their inner light, the God, the spark, the complex coexistence of play, identity performance, pain, and superficiality that gives rise to meaning. Not a conceptual meaning, but an experience of living out a persona. This might seem like built on nothing, but what else is there to build on?